bosom. I felt as if the world-warming Sun had fallen into my breast'. Through this association with Akbar, 'I and my family,' she admitted candidly, 'became famous throughout the seven climes.'

If these luminous claims may appear disquieting to a modern reader, or overblown, they were not so in the sixteenth-century Islamic world. For the Mughals were very aware of the mystical claims of Timur, who was said to be a descendant of the mythical Alanqua herself, a princess of Moghulistan who was impregnated by a divine ray of sunshine and gave birth to three 'shining' sons. They understood, also, Timur's title of Lord of the Conjunction and all its potent symbolism. The Mughals of Hindustan, as proud descendants of Timur, would adopt the idea of the Auspicious Conjunction as a symbol of legitimacy and Humayun, of all the Great Mughals, was the most devoted to trying to understand the workings of the cold and pitiless stars.

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*Also known as 'Timur the lame' due to an injury to his leg, and as Tamarlane.

*Amir and beg could be compared to the title of 'lord', whereas 'khan' would have been used only for a monarch.

*The sharia is Islam's legal system deriving from the Koran, and the fatwas—the rulings of Islamic scholars.

*Title for a Timurid prince or nobleman.

*Babur claimed the title of Shah, or Padshah, while his ancestors had not taken a title greater than amir.

†To Babur's great chagrin, Ibrahim Lodi's mother was unmoved by his largesse and tried to have him poisoned.

*Turki-speaking Timurid–Chaghatai Sunnis.

*Land grant of the revenue of a village or district.

*This figure is considered inflated by other historians including Sanjay Subrahmanyam and Ashok V. Desai.

*The system whereby the first-born son of a ruler automatically inherited the throne upon the death of the monarch.

†Sermon delivered from a pulpit by a Muslim preacher during Friday prayers. A new monarch would have his name recited on the first day after his coronation ceremony.

*At this stage all three brothers opposed Humayun though Hindal, youngest of the siblings, would soon come over to Humayun's camp.

*Akbar's foster father.

†A post equivalent to chief minister.